

Circus Freaks.

***“Come one, come all, to the greatest show on Earth and Beyond! Bear witness to the Amazing, the Terrifying, the One and Only...
Mothman!!!”***

Jo Huckleby cut the poster off the powerline log with his knife, Ol' Trusty.

“Can you believe it??” He said looking at the poster in his hands.

“Hardly, Huckleby! The Carnival ain't been 'round in ages!!” Fineas said.

“No, stupid, not the carnival! I meant ***Mothman!*** You really think they caught 'im??”

“Of course they did Huckleby! I mean, think of it. What with all that terrorizin' and flyin' and glowin' eyes and whatever else he was doin' up in dem hills up there, it was only a matter of time till our boys in blue brought out a net big enough to snatch 'im up!” Fineas said.

“I suppose so, Fineas. I hadn't really thought of it that way. You know, I really thought, what with him being a '***Psionic Creature of the Night***', like dem headlines said, you know, '***The Red-Eyed Monster of Mason***' and all... I just thought he'd be a little more ferocious like.” Huckleby said, then slapped the poster back onto a new nail in the log.

“Oh, '***psionic creature of the night***' my ass. Huckleby, here in the States we got ***guns!*** What's he gonna do? *Mindcontrol* my finger off the trigger? Hell, we probably shot fifty holes in 'im 'fore he even knowed what hit him! Just like we fixin' to do with dem Vietnamese folk, I'm sure!” Fineas said with a confident smile.

“I reckon I can't argue with that.” Huckleby replied and stuck his hands into his blue jean pockets.

“Nope, you can't!” Fineas replied. “So what we waiting for? Let's head on down!”

“I don't know...” Huckleby said, casting a glance to his feet “I got this feelin'...”.

“I mean, can't you read Huckleby? It says in plain text right here, 'Come one, Come all! If we ain't a member of the 'One' then we are *certainly* a member of the 'All'. Ain't the circus an important American tradition?” Fineas said before getting a headstart. Huckleby hesitated, but his heart hated to be left out, so it tugged him along.

The boys followed a distant trill of a calliope. Brass pipes whistling out “Entrance of the Gladiators” again and again, guiding the American way.

The Big Tent started pitch black before the show. The audience murmured amongst themselves until two large red lights appeared in the distance. A gasp reverberated around the room.

“There it is!” They said, “The glowing red-eyes!”

“Ladies and Gentlemen!” A voice in the dark said, and two more flaming eyes appeared to the left of the crowd. “Without further ado!” Another two flames on the right. Spotlights flicked on to reveal the Ringmaster standing atop a scaffold and brandishing a whip around himself. “I give you... The ***Red-Eyed Monster of Mason***, The ***Seven-Foot FLYIN' Menace***, The ***Psionic Creature of the Night... THE...***”

"MOTHMAN!!!!!"

The crowd roared a ferocious roar as four spot lights tracked over the audience converging on the center of the arena where the being sat. It was mothman. A four and a half foot tall, furry sort of creature sitting in the dirt. The audience gasped!

"By God! There it is!" Fineas whispered "It's as grotesque as I imagined!"

"I don't know..." Jo Huckleby said, "It's eyes ain't as glowin' or red as I imagined..."

Fineas might have responded, but the Ringmaster spoke first.

"O' Creature of the Night! FLY!!!" The Ringmaster said, whippin' his whip. Spotlights danced around the creature as it began to lift into the air, but its wings weren't flappin'. It screeched out into the dark and the audience 'OOO'ed in response!

"You see that??" Huckleby said "They got it connected to strings!" He pointed to a set of thin steel wires stretching from the Mothman's back and wings which glimmered, on occasion, in the spotlight as it lifted into the air.

"I said FLY, Creature! FLY!" the Ringmaster yelled, punctuating each "FLY" with a crack of the whip. On the second crack, the Mothman began beating its wings, guided in its flight by the cord.

"Fineas, I don't know if we should be here..." Huckleby whispered.

"Oh Huckleby, are you still scared of this 'creature of the night' business?? I mean, must I remind you? *He is a Moth*. Hell, if we really wanted we could probably strap a grenade to a flashlight and he'd damn near kill himself. I mean, seriously Huckleby, quit actin' like such a wuss, it's a carnival!" Fineas replied, munching on a handful of popcorn.

"I am not scared!" Huckleby said "It's just, like you said, he is a *Mothman*, Fineas. Part moth, part man. Neither of those two things eat people! I just don't know if he is deservin' of this..."

"Deserving?" Fineas replied. "Think of all that terrorizin' and flyin' it was doing! It chased a car for damn near miles!"

"I know he chased that car and all, Fineas! But I can't help but think... I mean, what if they just had them highbeams on?? Maybe he didn't mean to hurt nothin'!" Huckleby said, averting his gaze from the mothman, but a crack of the whip rang out and he flinched.

"Oh, don't be such a prude, Huckleby! I tell you what, maybe that mothman really *is* psionic. It's tuggin' on your mind!" Fineas said, condescending.

"It ain't the moth tuggin' on my mind, Fineas, it's my heartstrings!"

"Oh heartstrings, shmeartstrings, Huckleby! You oughtta just take out that Ol' Trusty knife of yours and cut those heartstrings off, they are controlling you! Relax and have some of this popcorn. It's nice and buttery afterall!" Fineas said, tilting the red-and-white bag towards Jo. A sea of cheers erupted from the audience as the mothman was craned over their heads, screeching in pain.

"You know what, Fineas? I think I'll take your advice..." Huckleby stood and drew Ol' Trusty.

"I'm gonna cut them strings." Huckleby said. And soon after the "Monster of Mason" was free that Ringmaster, and all them other circus freaks in that tent, finally reaped what they had sown.